

VICTORIA UNIVERSITY
Disability Services
Academic Support Workers
CODE OF CONDUCT
2018

1. Personal Boundary Guidelines

As an Academic Support Worker (ASW) you are employed in a professional capacity to provide in-class support to students in accordance with the *Disability Standards for Education (2005)*. The professional boundaries under which you practice are there to provide protection to yourself, your students and the organisations for which you work. It is vital to be aware of the guidelines relating to professional boundaries so that Academic Support Workers across all campuses can provide a consistent approach and service to students.

Students come from a variety of backgrounds and often present with complex issues. These students will often be known to Disability Services at Victoria University (VU) and be in receipt of confidential support from Disability Services at VU as well as external agencies. Due to privacy legislation you will not be privy to complete information regarding a student's diagnosis or health condition or case management plan. Although an ASW will most likely build rapport with a student during class it is important that the boundaries of this relationship are clear.

If an ASW student relationship develops into a personal/social relationship this could jeopardise your safety, the academic integrity of Victoria University programs, and the wellbeing of the student. Although the development of a personal relationship with a student may be well intentioned, it is not appropriate in an educational environment.

The following information is extremely important and must be incorporated into your professional Code of Conduct.

You are not permitted to engage in the following:

- Give out personal contact details to your student such as phone numbers, address or email. All contact with a student must be made by a Disability Liaison Officer (DLO), and questions should be directed to them, via your employment agency.
- Provide a student with a lift in your personal car (or vice versa).
- Be friends with students on social networking sites such as Facebook.
- Make arrangements to "catch up" with students out of class or during school holidays.
- Provide food, clothing or money for your student as this can be counterproductive to encouraging independence and may compromise other services the student may be receiving.
- Give advice or withhold information that may affect the safety or wellbeing of the student or others. ASW's are not to act as counsellors and should never have a 'confidential' conversation with a student. If a student says

or does anything that causes you to worry, please notify the DLO and tell the student that they need to discuss this matter with the DLO, who can make appropriate referrals.

- Form any relationship with the student outside the ethical boundaries of your ASW role.

2. Confidentiality Guidelines

Please ensure that you do not:

- Ask personal questions about the student's disability or medical condition.
- Talk about the student's personal situation to any other students or staff (including the teacher).
- Share information with other people about the support plan for individual students.
- Discuss the student's progress with anyone other than the DLO.

If you feel there is any immediate risk of harm to a student or others please notify the DLO, Victoria University Security or Counselling Services.

3. In-class and on campus expectations

- It is not the role of the ASW to participate in the class/ lecture in any way. For example: make comments, answer questions or prompt the student with responses.
- All students' work must be their own. It is not the ASW's role to have academic input into work produced by the student or 'help' them to pass.
- Do not take notes for your student if they are absent from class or if they leave early.
- It is not appropriate to have lunch or spend breaks with the student. It is important for the student not to be dependent on their Support Worker and to form their own friendships. If you are unsure, please discuss with your DLO.
- Requests for any extra support (in class or homework) needs to be approved by the DLO. It is the student's responsibility to organise this.
- ASW's are not permitted to attend off campus activities, unless approved by the DLO prior to activity commencement e.g. excursions.
- If the student has not turned up for class, you are required to wait for 30 minutes and then ring your Agency to inform them.
- ASW's are not permitted to assist students with any form of personal care (eg toileting, feeding and assisting with drinking)
- ASW's are able to use staff facilities such as kitchens, staffrooms and lounges. You may need to supply your own cup/utensils.
- Mobility assistance must not be provided to students until Victoria University has conducted a Job Safety Assessment on the additional task/s. You are not permitted to assist with mobility unless you have been instructed to in writing by the agency.

Contact your DLO if you have difficulties or questions regarding a student's individual, in class or on campus needs.

Please refer to your Employment Agency job descriptions for specific role expectations for Interpreter, Note Taker, Participation Assistant and Participation Assistant Plus.

4. Safety / First Aid Guidelines

If you feel unsafe at any time whilst on campus please contact security immediately. Please store campus security numbers in your mobile.

You are required to notify both a representative of Victoria University and your employment agency of any accidents, incidents or near misses immediately.

For any First Aid issues, please contact the Security / Campus Nurse

I have read and understood Victoria University's Code of Conduct for Academic Support Workers.

I agree to work within the above guidelines in my role as an Academic Support Worker.

Name: _____

Signature: _____ Date: _____

VU CONTACT NUMBERS

Victoria University Security: (03) 9919 4999

Emergency (03) 9919 6666

Disability Services: (03) 9919 5400 SMS: 0438 040 329

Counselling Services: (03) 9919 5400 (All Campuses)

Campus Nurse (St Albans only) 9919 4417